

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Biden commutes death sentences



President Joe Biden speaks during a Hanukkah reception Dec. 16 at the White House in Washington. **ROD LAMKEY JR./AP**

Gives life in prison to 37 of 40 before Trump takes over

By Will Weissert and Darlene Superville
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Joe Biden announced Monday that he is commuting the sentences of 37 of the 40 people on federal death row, converting their punishments to life imprisonment just weeks

before President-elect Donald Trump, an outspoken proponent of expanding capital punishment, takes office. The move spares the lives of people convicted in killings, including the slayings of police and military officers, people on federal land and those involved in deadly bank robberies or drug deals, as well as the killings of guards or prisoners in federal facilities. It means that just three federal inmates continue to face execution: Dylann Roof, who carried out the 2015 racist slayings of nine

■ A Chicago podiatrist who fatally shot a patient was among 37 people who had their federal death sentences commuted by President Joe Biden. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Black members of Mother Emanuel AME Church in Charleston, South Carolina; 2013 Boston Marathon bomber Dzhokhar Tsarnaev; and Robert Bowers, who fatally shot 11 congregants at Pittsburgh’s Tree of Life Synagogue in 2018, the deadliest antisemitic attack in U.S. history. “I’ve dedicated my career to

reducing violent crime and ensuring a fair and effective justice system,” Biden said in a statement. “Today, I am commuting the sentences of 37 of the 40 individuals on federal death row to life sentences without the possibility of parole. These commutations are consistent with the moratorium my administration has imposed on federal executions, in cases other than terrorism and hate-motivated mass murder.” Reaction was strong, both for

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Terry Price smiles after receiving a winter coat from The Chicago Help Initiative, an organization that provides meals and social services to those in need, outside Catholic Charities in the River North neighborhood of Chicago on Dec. 14. **TESS CROWLEY/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Weathering the cold

Charities across Chicago see huge shortage in coat donations as winter sets in: ‘We’re significantly thousands behind’

By Sylvan Lebrun | Chicago Tribune

As Chicago launches into months of winter weather, few items are more valuable than a warm coat. Yet nonprofits and community organizations that run winter coat drives say they are facing a serious shortage of donations this year as they try to help homeless and low-income Chicagoans weather the cold. Charities across Chicagoland rev up their annual drives over the holiday season, including for Christmas toys, books and food, in campaigns that aim to tap into people’s end-of-year generosity. But a plethora of nonprofits that collect and distribute coats to low-income, homeless, immigrant or refugee communities expected a deluge of holiday donors that never came this year.

The nonprofit Cradles to Crayons Chicago, which runs one of the city’s largest coat and winter clothing drives, entered this year’s holiday season hoping to provide 50,000 warm coats to children from low-income and homeless families. Their annual “Gear Up for Winter” drive runs from Oct. 1 through February. However, as of the start of last week, the organization found itself almost “completely out of coats” because of a drop in donations, according to Executive Director Dawn Melchiorre. Cradles to Crayons’ warehouse in North

Center had been emptied out, with only about 23,000 coats distributed so far. “We really can’t put our finger on what it is,” Melchiorre said. “Last year, we gave out almost 43,000 coats ... and were probably at about 30,000 coats at this point last year. So we’re significantly thousands behind.” With scientists predicting Chicago could see a colder and wetter winter this season due to the La Nina climate pattern, many organizers of coat drives of all scales say they are worried about the dangers

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Experts tie bird deaths to outbreak of avian flu

Dozens of waterfowl found dead in Illinois, according to officials

By Sheryl DeVore

Several dozen waterbirds, primarily snow geese, died earlier in December at Baldwin Lake State Fish and Wildlife Area in southern Illinois, and dead waterfowl have been found more recently in northern Illinois, state officials said. The bird deaths were likely due to a highly infectious and deadly strain of bird flu called HPAI. Specific numbers and species of birds that likely contracted the disease in northern Illinois are not yet available. Health officials are asking the public not to handle sick waterfowl or other wild birds that appear ill and not to take them to wildlife rehabilitation centers. Brad Semel was conducting a bird count in mid-December in Kenosha County just over the Illinois border when he noticed several dead geese frozen in a lake and some smaller ponds. “I assumed they were just from a cold snap,” said Semel, endangered species recovery specialist for the Illinois Department of Natural Resources. But then he learned these geese likely died of avian flu. “There are a number of significant events like this taking place in Cook, Lake and McHenry counties,” Semel said. “The flu started in southern Illinois a few weeks ago and began moving north,” Semel said. “It’s impacting mostly geese, but some cranes, herons and eagles.” Adam Sell, a Gurnee resident and birder, said he was out watching birds Wednesday when he encountered “a lot of dead waterfowl around the edge of the ice on Third Lake.” “It was mostly Canada geese, but there were some other smaller birds, likely ducks, that were also dead. It wasn’t just one or two,” said Sell, who logged

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Mayor losing 3 key leaders

Mayor Brandon Johnson will need to fill three key slots in his administration in the new year. His comptroller, chief policy officer and the head of the city’s Department of Family and Support Services all are exiting. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Nordstrom agrees to be taken private

Nordstrom has agreed to be acquired by Nordstrom family members and a Mexican retail group in a \$6.25 billion deal as the industry is being squeezed by discount chains and other competition. **Business**

Ill. group puts up Nativity scenes around nation



Evangeline Herff, 2, looks back at her family while standing near the Nativity scene in Daley Plaza in the Loop on Dec. 16. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

By Peter Breen
Chicago Tribune

On quiet nights during the Christmas season, Ed O’Malley enjoys visiting the Nativity scene he helps set up every year in an Arlington Heights park. He’ll check whether the wind has blown over a statue, or whether any lights have gone out. On relatively warm evenings, many families will be out and about, O’Malley said. Usually, they’ll end up in front of the depiction of infant Jesus. “Many times, you’ll see the little children will look in and they’ll touch the statues,” said O’Malley, 64, of nearby Prospect Heights. “A few times, you see a father or a mother just get down on a knee, and you can see that she’s explain-

ing to them what this is.” Despite some misconceptions — stemming from the First Amendment’s separation of church and state — private groups can put up Nativity scenes on public property as an expression of free speech after a federal judge ruled in 1988 that religious exhibits could be erected if maintained by private groups. Private groups can put up Hanukkah menorahs on public property to celebrate the Jewish holiday. Likewise, private groups can put up atheist, satanic, artistic, political, apolitical, eco-modernist or anarcho-pacifist displays on public property, if they so desire. The right to erect religious displays on government land

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